

Ethnographic Field Observation Paper

“Face” is described by Erving Goffman as “the positive social value a person effectively claims for himself [themselves] by the line others assume he has [they have] taken during a particular contact” (Goffman 185). In my words, people as part of the major society want to make a good impression of themselves during conversations with others, especially strangers, in order to build relationships and use them in the future for personal benefit. On the surface of this analysis of social interactions, many may argue that people are “actors” and only portray what they believe will “save face” in their situation and “lose face” when they forget to prepare for the role they need to portray. I spent time observing one-on-one interactions during a career fair at the University of Michigan’s Ross School of Business, and I would argue that “face” is actually a way to measure a person’s true persona, drawing from their feelings and emotions from each encounter and the way each person decides to present their face in interactions.

Starting with some observations from the event I took notes on, most students were dressed in suits and carried resumes, indicating that they all wanted to show a “professional” and prepared face to the recruiters. Some students were wearing t-shirts and jeans, indicating that they wanted to show the same face that they do in classroom settings to recruiters or that they did not prepare well to show a “professional” face. Typically, the students who were wearing jeans and socially “informal” clothing had their chance to speak with recruiters as much as the students who were dressed formally. That being said, it is socially known that students going to a career fair must wear proper attire or risk a loss of face in front of the recruiters who can serve as valuable economic connections. In Goffman’s “Interaction Ritual,” it is iterated that a person is “out of face” if they participate “in a contact with others without having ready the line of the kind participants in such situations are expected to take” (Goffman 186). However, instead of

displaying Goffman's principles that suggest students dressed informally would be ill-received by recruiters, I observed in one such interaction that a recruiter spent about ten more minutes speaking with an informally dressed student than they did with two formally dressed students in a prior interaction. The recruiter noticeably smiled more and talked less than they did with the formally dressed students. This observation suggests that this particular informally dressed student decided to present their face differently than the rest of the students, relying on verbal interaction over physical appearance, which was telling about the student's persona since society at Ross seemed to demand a certain physical appearance, which the student decided not to follow. This strange outcome of an otherwise predictable interaction shows that face can be presented in more than one way, but the way face is received is also not always dependent on social regulations or rules.

Another interaction I observed was between another formally dressed student and two different recruiters. This interaction was during the very beginning of the career fair, when there weren't many students in each line but there were many recruiters present. The student I observed was speaking with one recruiter. As the recruiter and student talked, it seemed to be a more awkward interaction where the recruiter talked a lot while the student listened and occasionally looked around the room during the conversation. The recruiter only spent two minutes or so speaking with the student, then moved onto the next. The same student traveled to a different table and had a similar interaction with another recruiter, then left the area of the fair where the recruiters were stationed. As Goffman indicates, a person's feelings about interactions correlate to how well-received their face is by the other party. It seemed as though the student I observed did not have good feelings coming out of both interactions with recruiters, and decided to leave so as to not experience other awkward interactions. This showed me that the student

perhaps was not prepared for the communication aspect of the career fair, or simply did not like any of the companies present, which told me more about the student's persona. In this case, I can draw similarities between my analysis of the interaction and Goffman's principles. Goffman indicates that people who "lose face" or feel their face is not well-received by the other party will try to "save face" in some way or another as to avoid any other negative feelings in their interactions. This particular student seemed to "save face" by leaving the room, thus avoiding any further interactions.

In the interactions I observed, I mainly saw students who typically interact with peers and in classrooms with different language, clothing, and speaking styles conform their face to fit the social demands that have been placed upon career fairs and the economic world. The idea of "professional" may seem normal, but it is odd that students must display a different face when most recruiters are well aware of college student interactions, with many recruiters having experienced student and peer interactions and being aware that most students they speak with are showing another face from their daily face. The student I observed who was informally dressed stood out to me, because they were seemingly well-received by the recruiter they spoke with, but they did not adhere to Goffman's principles, leading me to ask why students must adhere to the socially accepted face in this situation. All in all, these observed interactions show that face is something that shows what characteristics of social interaction are important to each individual, and their interactions show that what they choose to include in their face is directly related to their individual preferences, indicating that face is a good measure of a person's persona and not just a social practice.

Bibliography

Goffman, E. (1982). *Interaction ritual: essays on face-to-face behavior*. 1st Pantheon Books ed.
New York, Pantheon Books.

